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II

Chains of light race over
my stricken city.
Glittering web spun by
the white widow spider. 20

I see this wild arena
where we are harnessed
by alien electric shadows.

Even when the sun washes
the debris 25
I will recall my landlord
hanging in my room
and my father moaning in
Jesus' tomb.

In America all zebras 30
are in the zoo.

I hear the piston bark
and ibm[3] spark:
let us program rabies.
the madness is foaming now. 35

No wild zebras roam the American plain.
The mad dogs are running.
The African zebra is gone into the dust.

I see the shadow thieves coming
and my father on the specimen table. 40

1974

3. International Business Machines, or IBM, a computer manufacturer for which Dumas worked as a printing-machine operator for two years.

AMIRI BARAKA
(1934–2014)

Through his prolific and varied work as poet, playwright, essayist, critic, community organizer, and educator, Amiri Baraka established himself as one of the most intriguing, controversial, and influential figures in modern letters. It is hardly an exaggeration to say that Baraka was the main architect and propelling force of the Black Arts movement, nor even that contemporary African American literature and culture would not be what they are without his dynamic presence for over half a cen-

tury. In a career of encyclopedic he wrote numerous volumes of drama, poetry, prose, literary and cultural criticism, musical analysis, and political manifestos, and he has come to be regarded variously as an artist, politician, villain, and prophet. And yet however we choose to regard him, there remains something elusive about the image he presented for our consideration. For Baraka's trajectory as writer and social activist was marked by dramatic departures of place, theory, and personal association that rendered his life a continuous quest for an identity fully realized in the fusion of purpose and experience. As he wrote in his second volume of poetry: "I am a man / who is loud / on the birth / of his ways. Publicly redefining / each change in my soul, as if I had predicted / them, / and profited, biblically, even tho / their chanting weight,/ erased familiarity/ from my face." Baraka's openness to such perpetual redefinition lent his work a distinctive power, at once volatile and challenging.

Born LeRoi Jones in Newark, New Jersey to middle-class parents and a heritage of teachers and preachers, Baraka excelled in the institutions that structured his early life, graduating from high school at fifteen. And yet he was also restless and rebellious as a youth. Reflecting back on this stage of his life, he remarked, "When I was in high school I used to drink a lot of wine, throw bottles around, walk down the street in women's clothes just because I couldn't find anything to satisfy myself." That sense of unease despite success, leading to adoption of new and daring roles, was to become a hallmark of Baraka's evolution. After beginning college at nearby Rutgers University, Baraka transferred to Howard University, an historical black university that he felt suffocating in its official curriculum and prevailing culture. "Howard University shocked me into realizing how sick the Negro could be, how he could be led to self-destruction and how he would not realize that it was the society that had forced him into great sickness." And yet in classes in religion, philosophy, and literature, Baraka built the foundations of one of the most learned artistic imaginations of his generation. Moreover, through his extracurricular education from such luminaries as poet and scholar Sterling Brown, who offered students like Baraka and A. B. Spellman informal seminars in the history and meaning of African American vernacular traditions, Baraka gained a formative understanding of black oral forms as both aesthetic achievement and social statement. Thus Baraka's Howard experience proved paradigmatic in setting him against an institutional structure from which he nevertheless mined a storehouse of knowledge and an ambivalent inspiration.

After leaving Howard at nineteen, Baraka endured two years in the Air Force, which he felt "racist, degrading, and intellectually paralyzing." But once again, his struggle with social establishment proved productive, as Baraka used his time stationed in Puerto Rico, where he worked at the base library, to read through the canons of European, American, and African American literature. It was also in the Air Force that Baraka began to write poetry flavored with the jagged, pugnacious attitudes of the Beat poets who were then making their mark on American culture. Having contemplated such vocations as the ministry, medicine, and painting, Baraka left the service with a stack of miscellaneous writings under his arm. "Suddenly I said, 'Gee, I have all this stuff. I guess that makes me a writer.'"

Upon discharge from military service, Baraka brought that sense of artistic vocation to Greenwich Village in the late 1950s, where the Beat scene was in full swing, with writers such as Gregory Corso and Allen Ginsberg "howling" their audiences into a new consciousness, while Ornette Coleman, Thelonius Monk, Wilbur Ware, John Coltrane, and other principals of the "new music" challenged the boundaries of African American musical convention. During the next few years, Baraka established his reputation as a music critic, writing about jazz for *Downbeat, Metronome,* and the *Jazz Review* in a style that was simultaneously analytical and lyrical. Along with Hettie Cohen, whom he married in 1958, he founded *Yugen,* an art magazine that featured avant-garde verse and poetic manifestos. Expanding his role as literary impresario with his work on *Floating Bear,* a magazine he edited with Diane di Prima, and the founding of Totem Press, which published a strong cadre of Beat writers including Ginsberg and Jack Kerouac, he gained the moniker "King of the

Village," a nickname influenced by the French meaning of his birth name, LeRoi. For the first time of many, Baraka secured his place in the center of a literary movement driven by transgressive values underwritten by spiritual ambition and supported by self-made mechanisms for producing and disseminating radical expression.

Baraka's first collection of poems, *Preface to a Twenty Volume Suicide Note* (1961), reflects these sentiments, joining the Beats' assault on American middle-class society through verse that is at once savagely witty, plaintive, and defiant. And yet we hear in them also a subterranean rumble of a voice seeking an alternative sound. In his 1959 essay "How You Sound??," Baraka describes the primacy of this search as motivation for poetic creation:

> I'm not interested in writing sonnets, sestinas or anything. . . . only poems. If the poem has got to be a sonnet (unlikely tho) or whatever, it'll certainly let me know. The only 'recognizable tradition' a poet need follow is himself . . . & with that, say, all those things out of the tradition he can use, adapt, work over, into something for himself. To broaden his own voice with. (You have to start and finish there . . . your own voice . . . how you sound.)

Despite the provocative assertion of individuality in this statement, *Preface* reveals Baraka's use of available poetic conventions to be characteristic of the aggressive ambivalence he had displayed in his relation to social institutions. For against the vituperative refutation of inherited literary structures that we find in the poems' flamboyant experimentalism, we find a budding appreciation of forms developed within the African American tradition, especially the blues, that will soon emerge as a key feature of Baraka's post-Bohemian art and ideology.

In 1960, the Fair Play for Cuba Committee invited Baraka to visit Cuba, a trip described in *The Autobiography of LeRoi Jones/Amiri Baraka* (1984) as personally "revolutionary": "Cuba split me open." His encounters there with Cuba's publicly revolutionary artists were harsh and eye-opening, leading to unexpected self-criticism. As vividly portrayed in his 1961 essay "Cuba Libre," Baraka was accused by the Cuban culture workers of being a "cowardly bourgeoisie individualist" bent on "cultivating [his own] soul" rather than addressing oppressive conditions endured by the masses. Stung by these critiques, Baraka began to revalue his very status as "poet": "I'm a poet," he had told his Cuban counterparts; "what can I do?" Upon return to the States, he set out to answer that question by insistently probing the relation between words and actions, at times setting them in stark opposition, at times seeking to forge them into a powerful unity. Ultimately, this shift in his poetic project required for Baraka a broader change in literary and personal allegiances, as he gradually forsook bohemianism for the cause of black nationalism.

Before Baraka materialized this shift in 1965 by divorcing Cohen, moving from Greenwich Village uptown to Harlem and establishing himself as foremost spokesman of the emerging Black Arts and Black Power movements, he signaled the aims of radical change in three key works across different genres: *Blues People* (1963), a sociological study of black music; *The Dead Lecturer* (1964), his second volume of poetry; and the experimental plays *Dutchman* and *The Slave* (both 1964). In *Blues People,* Baraka interprets the history of black musical expression as a dialectic in which authentic forms of diasporic cultural expression are debased by mainstream commercial appropriation, then reborn in a rebellion of new forms. *The Dead Lecturer,* in such masterworks as the "Crow Jane" poems and "A Poem for Willie Best," self-consciously charts the transformation of Baraka's poetic voice from a "teller" of the dominant tradition to an invocatory agent of its destruction. And Baraka's plays present young black male protagonists forced from their cocoons of "white"-endorsed privilege into fatal struggles through which we glimpse the possibility of revolutionary rebirth. Providing a crucial bridge from the Bohemian stylings of his Greenwich Village sojourn to the nationalist formulations of his immersion in the black communities of Harlem and Newark, these works bear the Barakan signature of metamorphic necessity. Sometimes analytical or oratorical, at other times lyrical or visionary, the voice that emerges here searches for what Baraka, in the many

aesthetic tracts that he began to produce during this period, called "a post-Western form."

This ethos of change sparked Baraka's fast-developing commitment to revolutionary aims, which first took form in the black cultural nationalism with which he is most prominently associated. In the works that best define his contributions to the artistic and political climate of the Black Power movement—the poetry collections *Black Magic* (1968), *In Our Terribleness* (1970), and *It's Nation Time* (1970); the dramas *A Black Mass* (1966), *Slave Ship* (1967), and *Four Black Revolutionary Plays* (1969); the critical volumes *Black Music* (1968) and *Raise Race Rays Raze: Essays Since 1965* (1971); and the era-defining anthology *Black Fire* (which he edited with Larry Neal in 1968)—Baraka elevates the energy of resistance over any particular structure that might rise from the rubble of rebellious destruction. Thus along with the thematic emphasis on uncompromising black liberation we find that these writings, whatever their genre, offer innovative revisions of inherited forms, from the modernist poetic line that he had practiced as a young "Black Bohemian" to the theatrical naturalism that had ruled the stage before the ritualistic disruptions of *Dutchman* and *Slave Ship* inspired an explosion of African American dramatic invention.

Baraka's various experiments in artistic form and media were united by the intention of confronting, resituating, and ultimately replacing threatening authority, whether aesthetic or political. Much of the early poetry, especially that of *The Dead Lecturer,* poses a direct challenge to both high modernist influences (especially T.S. Eliot, Ezra Pound, and William Carlos Williams) and the next generation of poets associated with Baraka's Village years (Ginsberg, Robert Creeley, Charles Olson, and others). His overt quarrel with these authors concerned the relation of politics and art; art and politics were for Baraka equally "in the world," and in conceiving his duty as uniting them in service of uncompromised black freedom he found himself also attacking the stylistic habits that he had once shared with his forebears and peers in the American modernist tradition. In poems like "Black Dada Nihilismus" the need to break out of what Baraka perceived as privacy without authenticity and to emerge as an insurgent agent of social transformation led to new poetic strategies. In the exchange of muses by which Baraka declared, "The poor have become our creators. The black" ("Short Speech to My Friends"), African American oral modes—the dozens, scatting, shouts, chants, blues and jazz tonalities—already evident in *Preface,* became Baraka's dominant poetic resource. The later volumes such as *In Our Terribleness* and *It's Nation Time* continue to deploy the formal power of this black vocal repertoire while seeking to supplant their "universal" formulations with urgent political content. Meanwhile, Baraka's drama, from the explosively absurdist *Dutchman* to the ceremonially prophetic *Slave Ship,* developed and violently diverged from contemporary American theater, from Edward Albee's *The Zoo Story* to The Performance Group's *Dionysus in '69.* Likewise, Baraka's raucous satirical drama *Great Goodness of Life: A Coon Show* (1966)—written after his father had informed on him to the FBI—is, in part, a black nationalist answer to Jean Genet's *The Blacks,* just as Baraka's plays *Jello* (1965) and *Experimental Death Unit #1* (1969) are parodistic re-enactments of, respectively, popular entertainment (the Jack Benny Show) and European expressionism (Samuel Beckett's *Endgame).* In all of these works, a struggle for control of the available means of expression illuminates all other thematic interests.

The complexities of this struggle are perhaps most vivid in Baraka's plays, where it takes embodied form in confrontations of fully voiced characters. *Dutchman* is structured as an extended linguistic rivalry between Clay and Lula, including a contest in naming found at the heart of the play (*Lula.* "Are you talking to my name?" *Clay.* "What is it, a secret?). Clay's attempt at self-assertion through rhetorical resistance is cut short by his own recognition that a dependence on borrowed words, on the "metaphors" of Lula's "bastard literature," separates him from the cleansing language of violent acts. In *The Slave,* Walker likewise laments that "I learned so many words . . . but almost none of them are mine." Their entrapment in

foreign vocabularies involves a loss of cultural continuity, a divorce from the language of their shared but repressed origins in African-derived expressive values. As Baraka's theater progressed, leaving Clay and Walker at the threshold of an immense discovery that they could not embrace, the oppressive force of Lula is eventually transformed into the abstracted Voice of *Slave Ship,* which, after waging a prolonged war of sound against the captive black nation, suffers a death-by-uproar inflicted by the collective exclamations of the "old slave ship."

The very intensity of these battles of form and meaning illuminate the paradoxical insight that drives and unifies Baraka's writing through its various ideological phases: in seeking what the old man of *The Slave* calls a "meta-language," a rebel poet must incorporate the expressive presence of an alien idiom in order to transcend it. This complex lesson lies at the heart of Baraka's theoretical essays such as "Technology and Ethos," in which he expresses with almost self-mocking intensity his need to shape a new "kind of instrument" that can eclipse the standards and methods of his predecessors:

> A typewriter?—why shd it only make use of the tips of the fingers. If I invented a word placing machine, an "expression-scriber," *if you will,* then I would have a kind of instrument into which I could step & sit or sprawl or hang & use not only my fingers to make words express feelings but elbows, feet, head, behind, and all the sounds I wanted, screams, grunts, taps.

This humorous but determined confrontation with inherited instruments illuminates Baraka's often caustic attack on conventions, both artistic and social. The protagonists of such plays as *Dutchman, The Slave,* and *A Black Mass,* for example, encounter within themselves the very forms of consciousness they despise. As a revolutionary poet, Baraka decided that he could begin to say what he wished to be only by saying what he is not. And, like his self-limited and self-liberating heroes (for example, the titular subject of "A Poem for Willie Best"), he offered the lesson that one can create anew only with some recourse to the withering grammar of previous generations. But, Baraka's works tell us, by shocking that grammar sufficiently, by twisting it into unprecedented shapes, the revolutionary artist can generate new and living forms. It is only with the typewriter that he can inscribe into his art the blueprint for a new instrument.

In their search for an "expression-scriber" as fresh and radical as the content of a "post-Western" revolutionary vision, Baraka's works continued to evolve alongside his succeeding political and personal changes. With the publication of the essay "Toward Ideological Clarity" in 1974, Baraka announced his repudiation of black cultural nationalism and his turn to international socialism. "Fraternal liberation" became the watchword of the Barakan enterprise, signaling a type of relationship cleansed of both sentimentality and suspicion, in which the individual can feel trusted and encouraged. Baraka came to see this pan-cultural unity of oppressed people, especially peoples of color, as the best available means of attaining the ever-desired end of Baraka's lifelong quest: to break through the barriers of imprisoned individuality and establish a binding and just relation with the world of others.

True to his developing sense that change was the aim and not just the means of revolution, but with an abiding sense that old mechanisms bear their own revolutionary potential if properly recast, Baraka now fashioned literary work that experimented with new strategies for locating the proper "sound" of a global emancipatory practice, while emphasizing the blues inflections and jazz rhythms that he began developing in his earliest poems. In the poetry of *Hard Facts* (1975) and *Poetry for the Advanced* (1979), familiar idioms and timbres of black vernacular speech and performance are "transcribed" into the discourse of socialist critique. Though critics decried what they perceived as a psychological and conceptual crudity in these works, we find in them the touchstone of Baraka's ever-experimental poetic voice: the insistence that language itself is a major protagonist of ideologically charged historical drama. "The means of production" for Baraka is here not merely an evocation of Marxist economics but a reminder of the integral relation of expression and

practice in any program of radical social reformation. In contrast to the heroes of his early drama and narrators of his early poems, who are overwhelmed by "the motion of history" when they fail to advance its imperative of transformation, the voices of these later works carry forward the revolutionary impulse of his black nationalist works by finding the resolve to seize history by the throat and engage the world in deadly encounter. And, as with the figures that populate Baraka's black nationalist writings, these voices—particularly those heard in the later volumes *Transbluency* (1995), *Wise Whys Y's* (1995), *Funk Lore: New Poems* (1996), *Somebody Blew Up America & Other Poems* (2003), and *The Book of Monk* (2005)—conspire with history to forge isolated individuals into a communal whole, to realize in fact the idea that "the nation is like our selves."

Thus whatever his ideological position, Baraka attempted to mold a style of expression that could enable him to dissolve the differences between history and self—as well as between the different functions of self (political, artistic, personal) that he sought to unify by creating his work in the context of community organizations that he founded (in 1965, the Black Arts Repertory/Theater School; in 1966, Spirit House; in 1968, the Black Community Development and Defense Organization; in 1970, the Congress of African Peoples—to name only those most crucial to his leadership in the Black Arts movement). Through all his various changes of political philosophy, association, and venue, Baraka asserted that the flux of history is the essence of experience; that the individual will must come to terms with the logical necessities of change; and that revolution is the authentic form of the historical process. True to the spirit of that belief, Baraka's work, especially its spirited and innovative elevation of black experience over all that would denigrate oppress it, bestowed a profound legacy on the continuing story of African American creativity and aspiration.

Preface to a Twenty Volume Suicide Note

(For Kellie Jones, born 16 May 1959)

Lately, I've become accustomed to the way
The ground opens up and envelopes me
Each time I go out to walk the dog.
Or the broad edged silly music the wind
Makes when I run for a bus . . . 5

Things have come to that.

And now, each night I count the stars,
And each night I get the same number.
And when they will not come to be counted,
I count the holes they leave. 10

Nobody sings anymore.

And then last night, I tiptoed up
To my daughter's room and heard her
Talking to someone, and when I opened
The door, there was no one there . . . 15
Only she on her knees, peeking into

Her own clasped hands.

1961

Put it on him, poem. Strip him naked
to the world! Another bad poem cracking
steel knuckles in a jewlady's mouth
Poem scream poison gas on beasts in green berets[6]
Clean out the world for virtue and love,
Let there be no love poems written
until love can exist freely and
cleanly. Let Black People understand
that they are the lovers and the sons
of lovers and warriors and sons
of warriors Are poems & poets &
all the loveliness here in the world

We want a black poem. And a
Black World.
Let the world be a Black Poem
And Let All Black People Speak This Poem
Silently
or LOUD

1969

It's Nation Time

Time to get
together
time to be one strong fast black energy space
one pulsating positive magnetism, rising
time to get up and
be
come
be
come, time to
be come
time to
get up be come
black genius rise in spirit muscle
sun man get up[1] rise heart of universes to be
future of the world
the black man is the future of the world
be come
rise up
future of the black genius spirit reality
move
from crushed roach back
from dead snake head
from wig funeral in slowmotion
from dancing teeth and coward tip

6. Reference to the Green Berets, an elite corps within the U.S. Army.
1. "Get up . . . get up . . . get up": Reference to chorus of 1970 funk song, "Get Up (I Feel Like Being) a Sex Machine" by James Brown (1933–2006): "Get up (get on up) / get up (get on up) / Stay on the scene . . ."

from jibberjabber[2] patme boss patme smmich
when the brothers strike niggers come out
come out niggers
when the brothers take over the school
help niggers
come out niggers
all niggers negroes must change up
come together in unity unify
for nation time
it's nation time
Boom
Booom
BOOOM
Boom
Dadadadadadadadadadad
Boom
Boom
Boom
Boom
Dadadadad adadadad
Hey aheee (soft)
Hey ahheee (loud)
Boom
Boom
Boom
sing a get up time to nationfy
singa a miracle fire light
sing a airplane invisibility for the jesus niggers come from the grave
for the jesus niggers dead in the cave, rose up, passt jewjuice
on shadow world
raise up christ nigger
Christ was black
krishna was black shango[3] was black
black jesus nigger come out and strike
come out and strike boom boom
Heyahheeee come out
strike close ford
close prudential burn the policies[4]
tear glasses off dead statue puppets[5] even those
they imitate life
Shango budda black
hermes rasis[6] black
moses krishna
black

2. Foolish chatter (slang).
3. Yoruba god of fire, lightning, and thunder; "krishna": Hindu deity, an avatar of the supreme Vedic god Vishnu.
4. Prudential Financial: life insurance company founded in 1875 in Baraka's hometown of Newark, New Jersey.
5. In part, a possible allusion to the marionette Howdy Doody, eponymous protagonist of an American children's TV show in the late 1940s and 1950s, whose prominent 48 freckles stood for the nation's 48 states; the show was introduced by a tune called "Howdy Doody Time," which Baraka's poem parodies in title, tone, and diction.
6. Shape-shifting avatar of Satan; "hermes": Greek god of boundaries, messages, transitions, and trickery; "budda": Gautama Buddha, spiritual thinker on whose teachings Buddhism was founded.

when the brothers wanna stop animals
come out niggers come out
come out niggers niggers niggers come out
help us stop the devil
help us build a new world

niggers come out, brothers are we
with you and your sons your daughters are ours
and we are the same, all the blackness from one black allah
when the world is clear you'll be with us
come out niggers come out
come out niggers come out
It's nation time eye ime
It's nation ti eye ime
chant with bells and drum
it's nation time

It's nation time, get up santa claus (repeat)
it's nation time, build it
get up muffet dragger[7]
get up rastus for real to be rasta farari[8]
ras jua[9]
get up got here bow

It's Nation
Time!

1970

Wailers

(For Larry Neal and Bob Marley)[1]

Wailers are we
We are Wailers. Dont get scared.
Nothing happening but out and way out.
Nothing happening but the positive. (Unless you the
negative.) Wailers. We Wailers. Yeh, Wailers.
We wail, we wail.
We could dig Melville[2] on his ship
confronting the huge white mad beast
speeding death cross the sea to we.

7. Possibly a play on slang terms for a fool: "muppet" and "knuckle dragger" (or ape-like person).
8. Derived from "Ras Tafari," the pre-coronation name of Haile Selassie I (1892–1975), Ethiopian Emperor from 1930 to 1936 and 1941 to 1974. Rastafarianism arose in Jamaica in the 1930s as a religious sect whose adherents worshiped Haile Selassie I as the reincarnation of Christ and viewed Ethiopia as their spiritual homeland; by the 1960s, Rastafarianism had developed features of political resistance consistent with the contemporary Pan-African movement. "Rastus": derogatory term for a black man commonly used in minstrel shows.
9. God of princes, or princely god (from "ras," Amharic for prince; "jah": the Rastafarian term for Jehovah or God).
1. Neal (1937–1981), a leading theorist of the Black Arts movement; also a music critic, pianist, and flutist. Marley (1945–1981), Jamaican singer and composer. Marley and his band, The Wailers, introduced reggae music to a global audience in the 1970s. Marley was also an important political figure and peace activist in Jamaica.
2. Herman Melville (1819–1891), 19th-century American writer whose masterpiece *Moby-Dick* (1851) relates the story of Captain Ahab's vengeful search for the white whale that maimed him.